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Angie's list

December 2006 Circulation: 500,000

UNUSUAL SERVICE

Dream Authentics makes an arcade feel at home

by Paul F.P. Pogue

Four years ago, Rick Barretto faced a problem familiar to many homeowners: He had too much stuff in his basement. He had to consolidate somehow, but there was a hitch. His "stuff" included dozens of classic, full-sized arcade games, each a space-invading behemoth.

Inspired by this quandary, he drew from his business background and a passion for video games that dates to his junior high days and founded Dream Authentics, an Indianapolis-based company offering custom-built personal arcade systems. Barretto designed a platform that combined many games into one machine, allowing video-game enthusiasts to install a fully functional arcade in one corner of the home.

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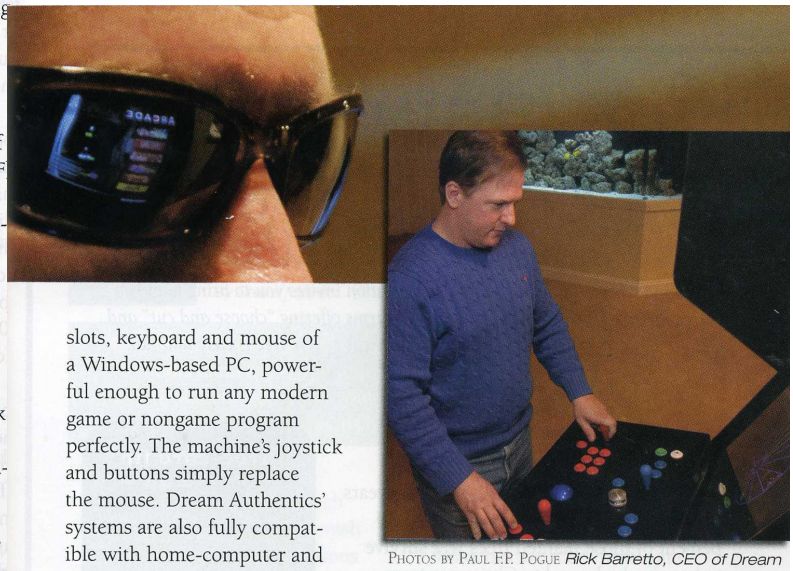
The systems' numerous features include stereo sound; bright, arcade-quality monitors and a wealth of options, such as glowing joysticks, trackballs, light guns and pinball flippers, replicating the control and feel of stand-up machines from the 1980s. It's all housed in a sturdy frame made of medium-density fiberboard (MDF), an engineered wood. Every one is custom-built at Barretto's seven-employee assembly shop with an average two- to four-week turnaround time.

Units come preinstalled with nearly 200 licensed games. Any PC-compatible collection of classic video games will also work allowing players to choose from thousands of arcade-perfect renditions of original games. Barretto says nostalgia plays a big part of the appeal. "If you play 'Pac-Man' on a computer screen, it looks too perfect," he says. "On ours, it's exactly as it was. You can see the pixels and everything. We want to keep the oldness, the retro factor."

Barretto's consoles aren't limited to old games. Just lift the control panel like a car hood and you'll find the tower, drive slots, keyboard and mouse of a Windows-based PC, powerful enough to run any modern game or nongame program perfectly. The machine's joystick and buttons simply replace the mouse. Dream Authentics' systems are also fully compatible with home-computer and entertainment networks. "A lot of the customers who buy from us want to do other things with [the system], realizing that it's a big investment," Barretto says. "People want to network it into the house. You can play music on it. You can put a movie in and watch it on here."



PHOTOS BY PAUL F.P. POGUE *Rick Barretto, CEO of Dream Authentics, enjoys the action on one of his company's full-sized, upright arcade-game machines.*

Bill Loguidice, a New Jersey-based procurement analyst and managing director of game-enthusiast website armchairarcade.com, acquired a Dream Authentics unit earlier this year to save space at home, where he has a vast collection of computer and video-game systems. "Something like this bridges the gap between home machines and arcades," Loguidice says. "It's very casual-play-friendly. Even friends and family who don't know how to play modern games can hop on and play 'Pac-Man' and 'Centipede' and not have an issue." Loguidice also likes its durability. "This 400-pound machine has survived two moves without a scratch," he says.

Prices range from $3,500 for a basic, two-player model to $6,000 and up for a fully loaded, four-player titan with custom marquee and trackball. Delivery charges range from $195 to $395 within the United States. "The coolness factor really sells them," Barretto says. "Who wouldn't want one of these in the basement if they could afford it?"

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